



Linux Mint 14 out

The new Linux Mint 14 desktop OS, 'Nadia', launched with several GUI updates and management tool improvements

Dell's second ARM platform

A second ARM server, being developed by Dell is going to be donated to the Apache Software Foundation for further application porting and software development

India ranks second globally in accessing private details of users

According to the latest transparency report released by Google, India ranks second in the world for accessing private details of its citizens, only after the U.S. The Google report lists out requests it received from governments across the world to access details of users of its various services.

Google's data reveals India had made 2,319 requests involving 3,467 users in the period from January to June 2012. The U.S. made 7,969 requests, while Brazil, which ranks third, made 1,566 requests during the same period. World-

wide 20,938 requests were made during the January-June period. The report says the information shared included complete Gmail account, chat logs, Orkut profile and search terms among others.

The requests for accessing user data from India had grown two-fold from 1,061 in July-December 2009 to 2,207 in July-December 2011, the report points out. According to the report, India has been consistently sending requests to remove content which it brands as defamatory and against national security. The court orders, however, to take down content has remained almost

Country	User Data Requests	Percentage of data requests fully or partially complied with	Users / Accounts specified
United States	7969	90.00%	16281
India	2319	64.00%	3467
Brazil	1566	76.00%	2640
France	1546	42.00%	1880
Germany	1533	39.00%	2007
United Kingdom	1425	64.00%	1732
Italy	841	34.00%	1054
Spain	531	52.00%	1037
Australia	523	64.00%	841
South Korea	423	35.00%	917
Poland	351	21.00%	458
Taiwan	271	63.00%	307
Hong Kong	192	33.00%	192
Portugal	184	14.00%	247
Argentina	137	38.00%	178

As you can see, India has sent around 2319 requests in the time period from January to June 2012, second only to the US

stagnant over the years, though requests from the executive and police have grown.

In the first six months this year, there were 20 court orders and 64 requests from executive / police that resulted in 596 items being taken down from the web. During the January-June 2010 period, there were only eight court orders and 22 executive / police requests, resulting in 125 items being taken down. Read about Google's previous transparency report here: <http://dg.it.in/UYK5fP>

"Though India is a large country with a significant number of internet users, this data is nonetheless an indicator of growing surveillance," *Times of India* quoted Pranesh Prakash, policy director at Centre for Internet and Society (CIS), a Bangalore-based organisation looking at issues of public accountability, internet freedom and openness, as saying. "India lacks a general privacy law that helps set guidelines for such user requests, despite privacy being a constitutional right as part of the right to life," added Prakash.

New VOIP interception technologies available to governments

Most governments have faced a tough time while tapping into Voice Over Internet Protocol (VoIP) services, but now a new spying technology empowers these agencies to 'silently record' conversations on online chat services such as Skype in real-time.

The VoIP services convert audio signals into digital data packets, which is highly costly and complex for third parties to intercept. This is why various countries have chosen to block VoIP services for security reasons. The US' FBI has sought the internet chat providers to build in 'backdoors' that its agents can use to wiretap suspects' conversations.

A California-based businessman has gained a patent for a 'legal intercept' technology which he says would allow governments to "silently record" VoIP communications. Dennis Chang, president of VoIP-PAL, a chat service similar to Skype, claims the technology will enable authorities to identify and monitor suspects only by accessing their username and subscriber data.

The patent says chats could also be tracked down by billing records that associate names and addresses with usernames. Such technology will help agencies intercept not only audio conversations but 'any other data streams such as pure data and/or video or multimedia data'

As you can imagine, some users who may use false subscriber data and services to hide their IP addresses could manage to circumvent the identification. However, the patent would restructure the way VoIP data is sent over the web, making it easier for the government bodies to track the conversations.

Back in India, the government has directed all the telecom operators providing BlackBerry smartphone services to implement the interception solution offered by Research In Motion by December 31 – a move that's supposed to help security agencies to keep a check on the possible misuse of the encrypted service.